This work of destruction continued until nightfall and exhaustion set in.

> Many of our men looked just like chimney-sweeps from the fire and smoke. On succeeding days other parties were sent, and the city of Kabul, with the exception of the Bala Hisar and the Qizilbash quarter, was utterly destroyed and burned to the ground . . . The houses were all built of light dry wood, and when once a fire was kindled it would have been impossible to stay the ravaging element. The conflagration lasted the whole time we were encamped in the vicinity . . . A large mosque which the Affghans had built in honour of their success over Elphinstone's army, and called the Feringhees' Mosque, was also blown up and destroyed.[96]

What Greenwood's jaunty narrative does not make clear is that, as well as destroying the empty shops and houses of their supposed enemies, the marauding British troops also committed what today would be classified as war crimes against their Qizilbash and Hindu allies. Indeed the peaceable Kabul Hindu trading community that had for centuries survived arbitrary arrests and torture by a whole variety of Afghan rulers bent on extorting their money was wiped out in just forty-eight hours by the depredations of the British, as an official inquiry later acknowledged. 'That much violence was committed at Kabul is unfortunately true,' Augustus Abbott later admitted to Ellenborough.

> The Afghans had all deserted the city before we arrived there, and only the Hindus and Persians remained. The Hindus, having fed and sheltered hundreds of our unfortunate soldiers after the destruction of the Kabul Force, naturally expected protection from us, and the Hindu quarter, tho' much exposed, remained fully occupied by the inhabitants with their families and property. The Persians [i.e. the Qizilbash] assisted in recovering our captive officers and men and were considered as friends. Their quarter, the Chindawol, was however too strong to be in danger for any rabble acting in defiance of orders. Then on the 9th October, 1842, the Engineers went down to destroy the market place, and a general idea seemed to arise in camp that Kabul was to be given up to plunder. Sepoys, many European soldiers and thousands of camp followers, crowded down and had little difficulty in entering the imperfectly walled town. The Troops sent as a covering party to protect the Engineers were assembled at one or two gateways and near the market place and knew nothing of the violence that was committed in the Hindoo quarter, where houses were broken open, women violated, property taken by force and the owners shot like dogs . . .[97]

Henry Rawlinson, the man whose sighting of Vitkevitch on the Afghan border in 1837 had started the first movements towards war, and who up to this point had just about managed to maintain his belief in the benevolence of British rule, was especially disgusted by the tawdry spectacle of the final days of the British occupation of Kabul. 'Numbers of people had returned